spending time at each other's houses. I no longer think of them as teammates, but as close friends. It makes sense that us three will take the long form team forward together and focus on that while the short form side goes in another direction. But a part of me is activated that will not accept any of the reasons. Instead, I can only say the same thing my body does – that I can still do this. I listen to my body and it gives me nothing but the desire to keep going. I refuse to retire officially from one-day cricket. I decide not to announce anything. I know the likelihood now of a return to the format is incredibly slim, given the tone with which this has been delivered to me, but I refuse to turn my back on it, even if it turns its back on me. If they need me, I will still be ready to do a job.

When the news breaks, I am honest with anyone that asks. I don't think it's correct, I think I have more to give, but I respect the decision if they truly think it's in their best interests. As I do so, the question creeps into my existence, at first weekly with a general out-of-interest air to it, but then it morphs into a daily, constant and borderline intrusive one: when do you think you will retire?

I go to see Mark Bawden – no longer working for the team – to talk to him about it. We go to the pub together, finding a table out of the way. I tell him that every five minutes, people are asking me when I'm going to retire. I feel nothing in my body or my performances that suggests I should even be entertaining it. He listens, sympathetically. Together, over one pub lunch, we concoct an approach. Every time I am asked it, or I hear it being talked about, rather than turning it into an emotional thing, why don't I reverse it and use it as singular motivation? I like proving people wrong, he says, and this is a golden opportunity to do exactly that. I thrive off confounding expectations, he says; think of it that way.

As the Strauss verdict lands and I get back to playing, I realise reluctantly that it's probably a good thing. I start to turn my ambitions to playing Test cricket for as long as I can. If I keep working hard, doing the horrible stuff daily in the gym, pushing through every morning that I wake up feeling like I don't want to run, every evening that I go to sleep not being able to brush my teeth, or unable to sit down because of a workload throughout the day, I can get through it; I can go further. I start to see it as an exciting challenge – to get to my forties still playing at the highest level. It would feel like breaking new ground.